

Area	Hardening Steps
Users & Accounts	Win + R → lusrmgr.msc • Review all local users • Identify unauthorized or unexpected accounts • Disable suspicious accounts rather than immediately deleting them • Check membership of Administrators, Remote Desktop Users, Backup Operators, and other privileged groups • Remove unnecessary privileged memberships • Disable the Guest account • Verify the built-in Administrator account configuration • Check for accounts with Password never expires enabled • Change authorized privileged-account passwords where competition rules permit
Password Policy	Win + R → secpol.msc → Account Policies → Password Policy • Enforce password history: roughly 10–24 passwords • Minimum password length: 12+ characters • Maximum password age: roughly 30–60 days • Minimum password age: 1 day • Enable Password must meet complexity requirements • Disable Store passwords using reversible encryption
Account Lockout Policy	Win + R → secpol.msc → Account Policies → Account Lockout Policy • Set account lockout threshold around 5 failed attempts • Set lockout duration around 15 minutes • Reset failed-attempt counter around 15 minutes • Avoid overly aggressive settings that could make account lockout easier to abuse
Local Security Policy	Win + R → secpol.msc → Local Policies → Security Options • Disable anonymous SID/name translation • Restrict anonymous SAM enumeration • Restrict anonymous share enumeration • Disable Guest • Review interactive logon settings • Configure UAC / Admin Approval Mode

	• Prefer NTLMv2 where compatibility permits • Configure SMB signing where appropriate • Review remote shutdown permissions • Review network logon permissions
User Rights Assignment	Win + R → secpol.msc → Local Policies → User Rights Assignment Review who has: • Access this computer from the network • Allow log on locally • Allow log on through Remote Desktop Services • Log on as a service • Log on as a batch job • Back up files and directories • Debug programs • Shut down the system • Corresponding Deny rights
Services	Win + R → services.msc • Review running services • Review services configured for Automatic startup • Investigate unfamiliar service names • Inspect executable paths • Check which account each service runs as • Investigate services running from user profiles, temp directories, or unusual locations • Disable unnecessary services only after confirming they are not scored/required
Potentially Unneeded Services	Use services.msc and investigate whether these are necessary: • Remote Registry • Print Spooler • Bluetooth services • Fax • SSDP Discovery • UPnP • Internet Connection Sharing • SNMP • Remote Desktop Services • IIS/FTP components

	• Third-party remote-access tools Do not blindly disable these.
Windows Firewall	Win + R → wf.msc • Ensure firewall is enabled for Domain, Private, and Public profiles • Review inbound rules • Review outbound rules • Remove suspicious or overly broad allow rules • Look for rules tied to unknown executables • Restrict management ports where appropriate • Expose only required/scored services
Listening Ports	Win + R → cmd or PowerShell netstat -anoGet-NetTCPConnection -State Listen • Inventory listening TCP ports • Check UDP listeners • Map PID → process • Investigate unexpected listeners • Compare exposed ports with required services
Processes	Win + R → taskmgr Also useful: tasklistGet-Process • Look for unfamiliar processes • Check processes running as SYSTEM • Investigate executables running from temp directories or user profiles • Correlate suspicious PIDs with network connections
SMB / File Shares	Win + R → fsmgmt.msc Also: net shareGet-SmbShare • Inventory shares • Remove unnecessary shares • Check Everyone permissions • Review share permissions and NTFS permissions • Check for anonymous or guest access • Review administrative shares • Disable SMBv1 where compatibility permits

NTFS Permissions	File Explorer → right-click folder → Properties → Security Review important folders for: • Everyone: Full Control • Users: Full Control • Writable service executables • Writable web roots • Writable application directories • Suspicious ACL entries
Scheduled Tasks	Win + R → taskschd.msc Also: schtasks /query /fo LIST /v • Look for unknown tasks • Look for tasks running as SYSTEM • Review tasks triggered at startup/logon • Investigate PowerShell or CMD tasks • Investigate scripts running from temp folders, AppData, or user profiles • Look for randomly named tasks
Startup / Persistence	Win + R → shell:startup Also check registry: HKLM\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\RunHKCU\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run • Review Startup folders • Review Run/RunOnce keys • Review services • Review scheduled tasks • Review PowerShell profiles • Review Winlogon configuration • Investigate unexpected persistence mechanisms
Remote Desktop	Win + R → SystemPropertiesRemote • Disable RDP if it is not required • If required, enable Network Level Authentication • Restrict allowed users • Review Remote Desktop Users group • Restrict RDP through firewall rules where appropriate

WinRM / Remote Management	Win + R → services.msc and check Windows Remote Management Get-Service WinRM • Determine whether WinRM is required • Disable or restrict it if unnecessary • Review other remote-management software such as VNC, TeamViewer, AnyDesk, OpenSSH, etc.
Windows Defender	Win + R → windowsdefender: PowerShell: Get-MpComputerStatus • Verify Defender is enabled • Verify real-time protection • Check definition status • Review exclusions • Look for suspicious excluded folders, processes, or extensions
Installed Software	Win + R → appwiz.cpl • Inventory installed programs • Look for remote-access tools • Identify unnecessary network services • Identify outdated or suspicious applications • Avoid uninstalling anything until you understand service dependencies
Event Logs	Win + R → eventvwr.msc Review: • Security • System • Application • PowerShell • Defender logs • Look for failed logons • New account creation • Group-membership changes • Service creation • Scheduled-task creation • Suspicious PowerShell activity • Unexpected shutdowns/reboots

Audit Policy	Win + R → secpol.msc → Local Policies → Audit Policy or Advanced Audit Policy Configuration Consider auditing: • Account logon • Account management • Logon/logoff • Policy changes • Privilege use • Process creation • System events • Object access where useful
PowerShell Security / Logging	Win + R → gpedit.msc where available Review PowerShell-related policy and logging settings. • Enable Script Block Logging if appropriate • Enable Module Logging if appropriate • Review PowerShell profiles • Inspect suspicious scripts/history • Watch for encoded or unexpected PowerShell execution
Network Configuration	Win + R → ncpa.cpl Also: ipconfig /all • Verify IP address • Verify gateway • Verify DNS servers • Look for unexpected network adapters • Check whether static addressing was modified
Hosts File / DNS Redirection	Check: C:\Windows\System32\drivers\etc\hosts • Look for unexpected host redirects • Verify DNS settings • Investigate suspicious entries pointing important services to incorrect addresses
IIS	Win + R → inetmgr If IIS is a scored service:

	• Inventory sites • Review application pools • Review authentication settings • Disable directory browsing unless needed • Review <code>web.config</code> • Inspect IIS logs • Review web-root permissions • Check for unexpected scripts/files • Review application-pool identities
Computer Management	Win + R → <code>compmgmt.msc</code> Useful all-in-one console for: • Local Users and Groups • Shared Folders • Event Viewer • Services • Device Manager • Disk Management
Group Policy	Win + R → <code>gpedit.msc</code> • Review security-related local policies • Review Remote Desktop configuration • Review Windows Defender configuration • Review PowerShell logging • Review Windows Update settings • Look for suspicious policy changes
Registry	Win + R → <code>regedit</code> Use mainly to inspect known persistence/security locations. • Run/RunOnce • Winlogon • Service configuration • Security-related configuration *Avoid making broad registry changes during competition without understanding their effect.

Active Directory	Win + R → dsa.msc on a DC/admin workstation • Review Domain Admins • Review Enterprise Admins • Review Administrators • Review Backup/Server/Account Operators • Identify suspicious users • Review privileged group membership • Check service accounts • Review recently created accounts
Domain Group Policy	Win + R → gpmmc.msc • Review linked GPOs • Check password policies • Check security policies • Review user-right assignments • Review firewall configuration • Look for unexpected or malicious policy changes
System Configuration	Win + R → msconfig • Review startup configuration • Review boot settings • Investigate unexpected boot options • Do not disable Microsoft/system components blindly
Device Manager	Win + R → devmgmt.msc • Look for unexpected network adapters or devices • Verify important hardware is functioning normally
System Information	Win + R → msinfo32 • Identify OS version/build • Check system role/details • Review startup information • Record baseline machine information
Windows	Win + R → optionalfeatures • Review enabled Windows features

Features	• Look for unnecessary legacy components • Check SMB1 • Check Telnet/TFTP/IIS/FTP features • Only remove features after checking scored-service requirements
Quick Baseline Commands	<pre> Hostname whoami whoami /groupsipconfig /allnet usernet localgroup administratorsnet sharenetstat -anotasklistsc queryschtasks /query /fo LIST /v </pre>
CCDC Safety Check	Before changing anything major, ask: • Is this service scored? • Does another system depend on it? • Will changing this password break an application? • Will this firewall rule block the scoring engine? • Can I disable instead of delete? • Do I have a record of the original configuration?